

A Planted Forest and a Parade Ground: Harajuku and Yoyogi

Two farming villages on a river terrace became the front approach to a shrine built entirely by human hand, and a shogunal drill field became, in turn, an aviation pioneers' runway, occupied family housing, an Olympic village and a park. Little of that sequence shows on the surface today, but the street plan still runs on it.



原宿・代々木（東京都渋谷区）

In this dossier

1. A history of the district (6 chapters, about 1500 words)
2. Timeline
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Written in English from Japanese library sources — chiefly books digitised by the National Diet Library — and official records. Superscript numbers point to the numbered sources at the end, with page frames for the digitised books.

Two villages on a terrace above a stream

The land here is drier and higher than the river districts nearer the bay: the Geospatial Information Authority classes most of the study area as terrace and slope rather than flood plain, cut into by the small valley of a stream once called the Onden River. Before Edo grew this far, that terrace held two separate farming villages of Toshima District, Harajuku and Yoyogi, each recorded in an early nineteenth-century gazetteer with its own parish temple: Harajuku's Ryuganji kept a bell cast in 1762, Yoyogi's Fukusenji one cast in 1719. Onden, the third hamlet folded into this dossier's ground, took its name, a 1917 town survey records, from Onda Gorozaemon, a retainer of Uesugi Sadamasa who retired here and whose farming descendants gave the place its familiar name before the Tokugawa era respelled it with the characters now read Onden.¹²¹⁵

Under the shogunate the whole terrace was parcelled out to daimyo and hatamoto as detached residences and to temples as endowed land, the same 1917 survey notes: the Tokugawa main family's later estate had been the Kishu domain's own flower garden, the site of the Imperial Guard's 4th Regiment had belonged to a hatamoto named Mizuno, and the district still called Shin-yashiki, "new residence," took its name from land once held by Naito Tango-no-kami and later divided among his retainers. Harajuku's own name is explained two ways in the same source: either from a post-station on the old road from Kamakura to Mutsu province, or, in a tradition kept at Ryuganji, from the eleventh-century general Minamoto no Yoshiie mustering his troops here before an eastern campaign, a story the slope by the temple gate still marks as Seizoroizaka, "muster slope."²

The same survey preserves the origin story of the district's older Hachiman shrine, on ground in Sendagaya aza granted eight koku eight to of shogunal shrine-land: villagers are said to have seen strange lights and clouds over an ancient grove here, with white doves flying off toward the west, and built a small shrine they called Hato-no-mori, the Dove Grove; in 860 the itinerant priest Jikaku Daishi is said to have enshrined Empress Jingu, Emperor Ojin and Amenokoyane there on the model of Usa Hachiman, two and a half centuries before either Harajuku or Yoyogi is otherwise attested by name. A local warrior of the Shibuya clan later credited a battlefield victory to an arrow he found before the shrine after praying there, the same tradition holds, and went on to govern what were remembered as Shibuya's seven manors.²

A parade ground for a modernizing army

Meiji rule turned the largest open part of this terrace into a military exercise field, the Yoyogi Parade Ground, and for three decades it did service as much for spectacle and invention as for drill. Visiting royalty were reviewed there: a 1922 commemorative album of the Prince of Wales's state visit devotes two full plates to the military review staged for him at Yoyogi. More lastingly, it was here, on 19 December 1910, that the army officers Tokugawa Yoshitoshi and Hino Kumagoro made Japan's first officially recognized powered flights, an event the National Diet Library's own history of Japanese aviation still marks as the country's aviation centenary starting point: Tokugawa's Henri Farman biplane, bought in France, reached about 70 meters and 53 kilometers an hour over roughly three kilometers in a four-minute flight, after the two men had spent four months training in Europe that year.⁴⁵

By the 1910s the farming villages around the parade ground were filling with commuters. Harajuku, Onden and Sendagaya had merged into a single Sendagaya village in 1889, the 1917 town survey records, and its population grew sharply after the wars with China and Russia as Tokyo's middle class looked for houses within reach of the city; in 1907 the village became Sendagaya Town outright. A 1922 land-value survey of the town shows Harajuku itself already subdivided into named micro-districts such as North Harajuku and South Harajuku, evidence of how built-up the old village core had become even before its next transformation.²³

A shrine, and a forest built to outlast its builders

That transformation was Meiji Shrine. After Emperor Meiji's death in 1912 and Empress Shoken's in 1914, the Home Ministry set up a Meiji Shrine Construction Bureau in 1915, and the 1917 Sendagaya town survey, written while the work was still under way, already notes that the shrine's inner precinct was fixed on the Yoyogi imperial estate, its outer garden on the Aoyama parade ground, and that both the front approach and a back approach linking the two would run through the town, reason enough, its compilers felt, to record the shrine's coming specially even before it opened. The shrine was dedicated on 1 November 1920, and its outer garden, with the ginkgo avenue still associated with it, was finished in October 1926.²⁸⁹

The forest around the inner shrine was not inherited but designed. Three forestry and landscape specialists, led by Honda Seiroku, surveyed some 88 shrine forests across Japan and, against the Home Minister's own preference for a conifer plantation on the Nikko model, argued for a broadleaf forest that would need almost no maintenance and would evolve through natural succession over fifty, a hundred and a hundred and fifty years. About 100,000 trees, donated from across the country, were set out over the roughly 70-hectare inner precinct by some 110,000 volunteer young people, an act of civic labor on a scale Tokyo had not seen before.⁹

1932: the ward that did not want to be born

Tokyo's expansion from 15 to 35 wards in 1932 required Sendagaya to give up the independence it had only gained in 1907, merging with Shibuya and Yoyohata towns on 1 October that year to form Shibuya Ward. Sendagaya, debt-free and home to the Tokugawa family's main residence, fought the merger hard, a Kokugakuin University account of the episode records: it had petitioned since 1930 to join the more established Yotsuya or Akasaka wards instead, proposed the alternative name Jingu-ku, "Shrine Ward," in deference to its new neighbor, and marked the merger date itself with banners reading "never forget the first of October," a day its residents called Ankoku De, "Dark Day." The new ward assembly, dominated by Shibuya and Yoyohata representatives, rejected the appeal, and the Sendagaya name survives today only as a district within Shibuya.¹⁰

1945: the shrine burns, the parade ground becomes a base

The shrine's own chronology records what the war did to it with unusual precision: on 14 April 1945, American B-29 bombers set its main hall and worship hall ablaze, forcing worship to stop for two days while its sacred objects were moved into the treasure house for safety. Reconstruction funds began arriving within days, and a temporary worship hall went up that same month, but the permanent rebuilding took over a decade; the rededication of the new main hall, attended by more than six thousand people including members of the imperial family, was finally held on 31 October 1958.⁶⁷

Across the old parade ground, the occupation of Japan left a longer mark. The former Yoyogi Parade Ground became Washington Heights, family housing for American service personnel, and it stayed under American control until Tokyo's own Olympic ambitions reclaimed it: for the 1964 Games it served as the main athletes' village, and one surviving cottage, once home to the Dutch team, still stands in what is now Yoyogi Park, reopened in 2026 as a cafe. Beside it, on part of the same reclaimed ground, Kenzo Tange's National Yoyogi Stadium, built for the Games' swimming and basketball events and completed in September 1964, used a then-unprecedented cable suspension roof that a workforce of some 200,000 built in eighteen months, a construction feat covered on national television as it happened.¹¹¹⁴

Reading the ground today

Meiji Shrine's forest, still developing broadly as its Taisho-era planners predicted, remains the largest single feature on the map, and Omotesando, opened as the shrine's formal approach in 1920, still runs dead straight toward it from Aoyama-dori. West of the shrine, the old Onden River survives only as a route: it was culverted and its bed became a footpath that Shibuya Ward has since officially named Cat Street, continuing south past Omotesando as the Former Shibuya River Promenade, with old bridge-post markers still standing along the way to show where it once ran in the open.⁹¹²¹³

Yoyogi Park's slightly irregular paths and open lawns, unusual for a Japanese metropolitan park, are themselves a trace of its double reuse: first as barrack housing laid out on the old parade ground's grid, then as an Olympic village whose surviving buildings and street pattern still shape the park built over them after 1964. Between the shrine's dense forest and the park's open ground, the terrace-and-slope landform recorded for this district by the land-survey authority is easiest to feel on foot, in the short, sharp drop from Sendagaya's old high ground down toward the former streambed that Cat Street now follows. ^{11 15 16}

Timeline

1762 / 1719	Bell-casting dates recorded for Harajuku village's Ryuganji and Yoyogi village's Fukusenji, evidence both existed as separate Edo-period villages. ¹
1889	Harajuku, Onden and Sendagaya villages merge into a single Sendagaya village. ²
19 December 1910	Tokugawa Yoshitoshi and Hino Kumagoro make Japan's first officially recognized powered flights at Yoyogi Parade Ground. ⁵
1907	Sendagaya village becomes Sendagaya Town as Tokyo's commuter suburbs expand. ²
1915	The Meiji Shrine Construction Bureau is established after the deaths of Emperor Meiji (1912) and Empress Shoken (1914). ⁹
1 November 1920	Meiji Shrine is dedicated; its front approach, Omotesando, opens the same year. ⁸⁹
October 1926	Meiji Shrine's outer garden is completed. ⁹
1 October 1932	Sendagaya, Shibuya and Yoyohata towns merge into Shibuya Ward, against fierce Sendagaya resistance. ¹⁰
14 April 1945	American B-29 bombing burns Meiji Shrine's main hall and worship hall. ⁶
31 October 1958	Meiji Shrine's rebuilt main hall is rededicated. ⁷
1964	The former Washington Heights site serves as the Tokyo Olympics' athletes' village; the National Yoyogi Stadium is completed in September. ¹¹¹⁴
20 October 1967	The former parade-ground and Olympic-village site opens as Yoyogi Park. ¹¹

Walking notes

Places to stand and look, in walking order. Straight-line distances only; check today's access and opening before you go.

- 1

Omotesando 表参道. Meiji Shrine's formal approach, laid out from Aoyama-dori to the shrine and opened in 1920 alongside the shrine itself, still runs on its original straight line.⁹ [map](#)
- 2

Meiji Shrine forest and main hall 明治神宮の杜・本殿. A deliberately designed broadleaf forest planted from 1915 by some 110,000 volunteers; the main hall was rebuilt after the 1945 firebombing and rededicated in 1958.⁷⁹ [map](#)
- 3

Cat Street キャットストリート (旧渋谷川遊歩道路) . A ward-designated footpath following the culverted course of the old Onden/Shibuya River south past Omotesando; old bridge-post markers survive along the route.¹²¹³ [map](#)
- 4

Yoyogi Park 代々木公園. Former Yoyogi Parade Ground, then the postwar Washington Heights family-housing site, then the 1964 Olympic athletes' village; a surviving cottage once housing the Dutch team still stands near the park entrance, reopened in 2026 as a cafe.¹¹ [map](#)
- 5

National Yoyogi Stadium 国立代々木競技場. Kenzo Tange's cable-suspension-roofed arena, built on part of the same former parade ground for the 1964 Olympics' swimming and basketball events, completed that September.¹⁴ [map](#)
- 6

Takeshita-dori 竹下通り. Runs through the old core of Harajuku village, subdivided into named micro-districts such as North and South Harajuku by the time of a 1922 land-value survey.³ [map](#)

Walk map



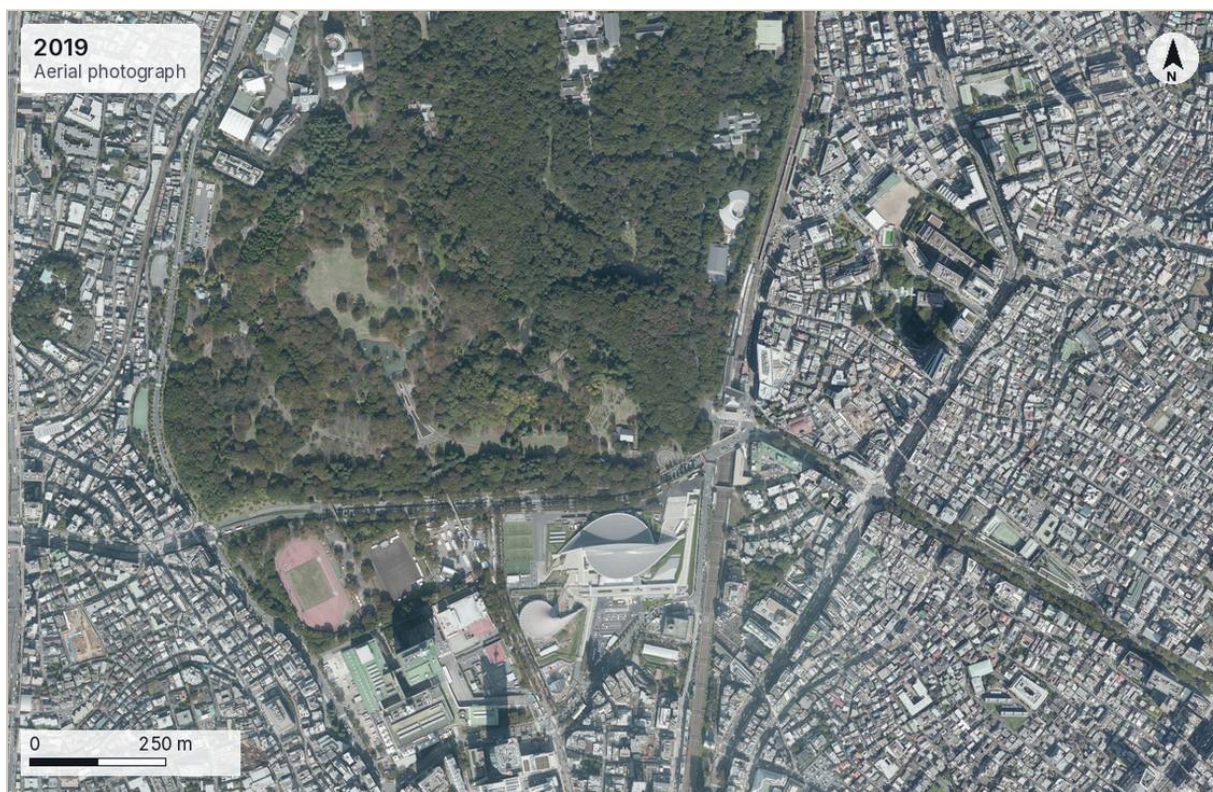
The walking stops, numbered as in the notes, on the latest GSI aerial photograph (2.3 × 1.6 km, north up). Lines join the stops in order and are not a route; follow streets on the ground. Each stop in the notes links to a map app.

- | | |
|---|---|
| 1 Omotesando map | 4 Yoyogi Park map |
| 2 Meiji Shrine forest and main hall map | 5 National Yoyogi Stadium map |
| 3 Cat Street map | 6 Takeshita-dori map |

The same ground, c. 1936–1942 and 2019



c. 1936–1942 aerial photograph — GSI Tiles *ort_riku10*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. North is up; the frame is identical in both images.



2019 annual orthophoto — GSI Tiles *nendophoto2019*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. Capture dates within a mosaic can differ from place to place.

How to compare. Anchor on features that rarely move — river banks, rail lines, shrine and temple grounds, main roads — then look for what changed around them. Differences in tone come from film, camera and season, not from the land itself.

The decades in between

Every further GSI series that covers the same frame, oldest first. Each series is a compilation: photographs within one series were taken on different dates, which is why seams and changes of tone can appear inside a frame.



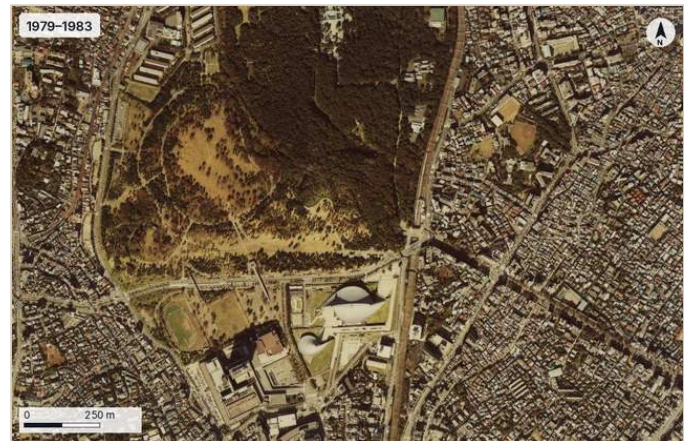
1945–1950 (US military photography) · GSI Tiles *ort_USA10*, processed



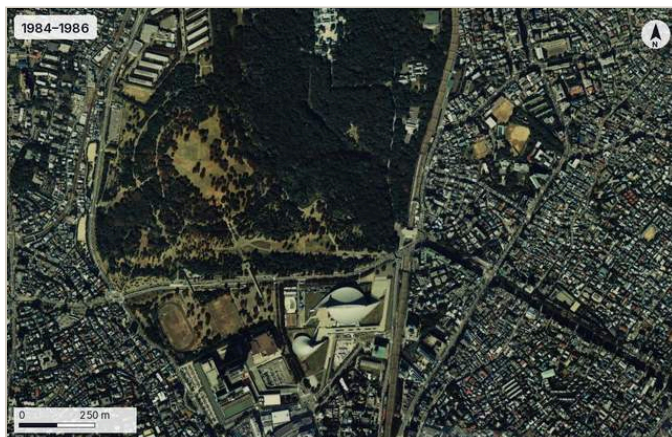
1961–1969 · GSI Tiles *ort_old10*, processed



1974–1978 · GSI Tiles *gazo1*, processed



1979–1983 · GSI Tiles *gazo2*, processed

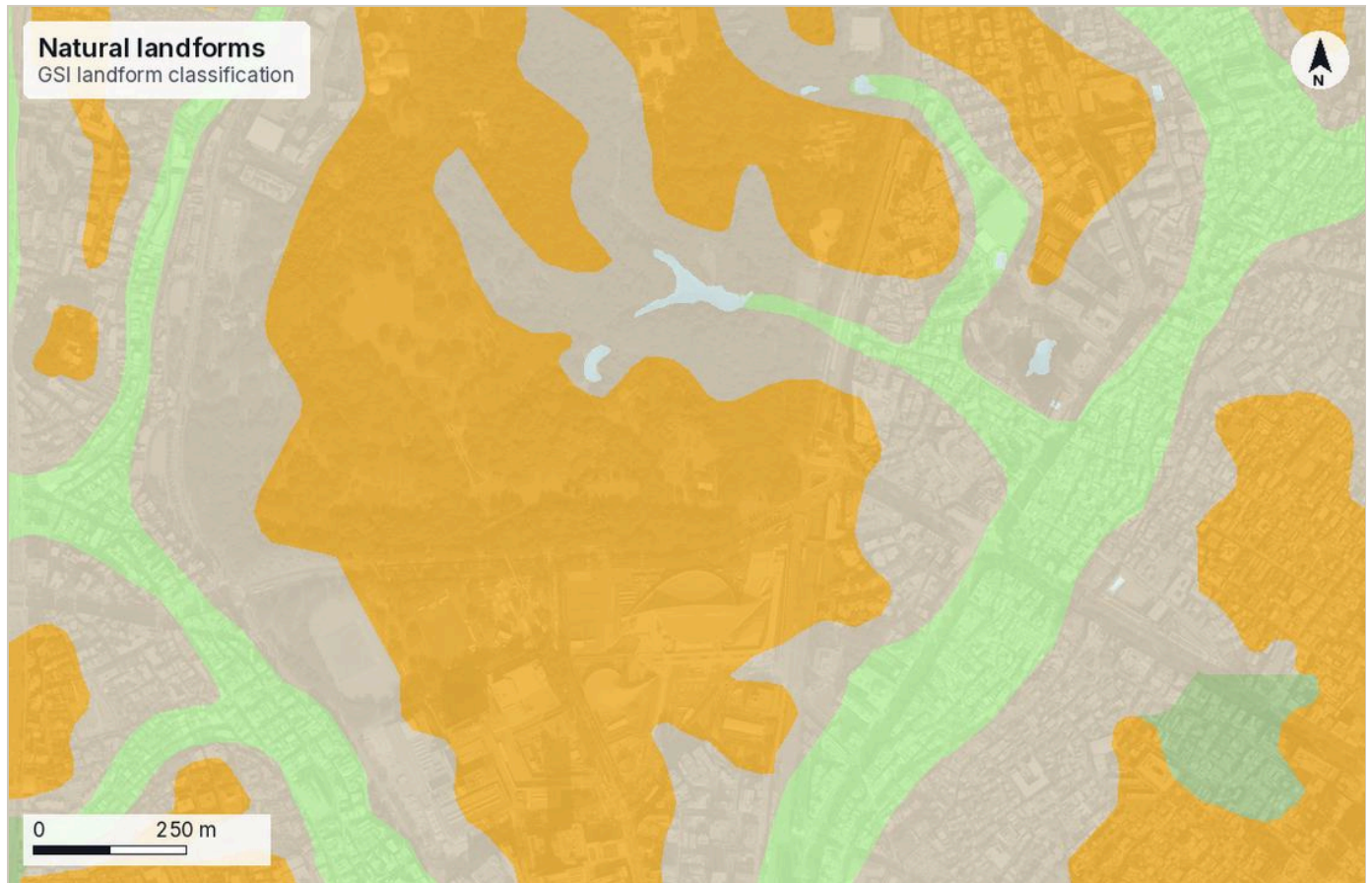


1984–1986 · GSI Tiles *gazo3*, processed



1987–1990 · GSI Tiles *gazo4*, processed

Rivers, shorelines and terraces



Natural landforms as classified by GSI, over a recent aerial photograph in gray. Dark blue outlines mark former river channels.

 Mountain and hill slopes 41%	 Plateaus and terraces 41%
 Floodplain and coastal plain 16%	 Hollows and shallow valleys 1.5%
 Water 0.5%	

What the main landforms mean

Mountain and hill slopes (41%). Ridges, valleys and fairly steep ground, including terrace-scarp slopes and volcanic ground. Heavy rain or earthquakes can trigger slope failures, debris flows and landslides.

Plateaus and terraces (41%). Flat ground standing in steps above its surroundings, left behind as the land around it was eroded. River flooding is rarely a threat unless the terrace is only slightly above the river; watch the slopes at its edges. Firm ground: shaking is relatively weak and liquefaction is unlikely.

Floodplain and coastal plain (16%). Low, flat ground of little relief, built from sand and mud left by floods, or former seabed that emerged. River flooding. Ground is softer nearer the coast and shakes somewhat more; liquefaction tendency is strong on coastal plains and somewhat strong on floodplains. Storm surge near the coast.

Descriptions translated and condensed from GSI's landform-classification legend. They describe tendencies of each landform type, not the condition of any individual plot.

Fill, reclamation and the fields beneath the town



Hatching: man-made ground as classified by GSI. Teal outlines: former sea, river or pond. Dark blue outlines: former river channels.



GSI “Meiji-era lowland” data, traced from topographic maps of the 1880s–1900s; GSI warns that positions can be off by a considerable distance, especially in the Kanto and Kinki regions. Only low, wet or open ground was traced: towns, dry fields and forest of the period are left blank.

Man-made ground

-  Cut ground 27%
-  Filled and reclaimed land 20%

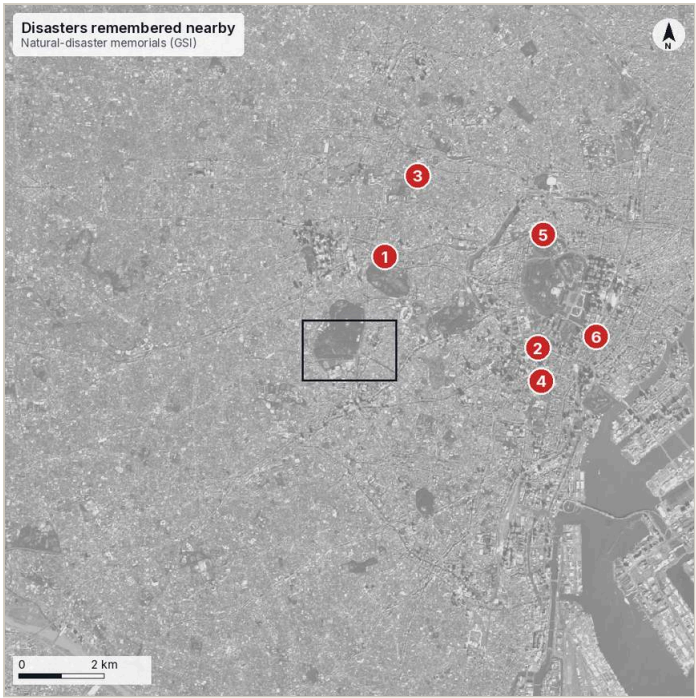
Cut ground (27%). Ground made by cutting into slopes of mountains or terrace edges. Depending on the cut slope, heavy rain or earthquakes may bring it down; the ground itself is generally firm.

Filled and reclaimed land (20%). Ground raised with fill, land made by dumping soil into the sea, rivers or ponds, or valleys filled in. May flood if not raised enough; on hills, rain or earthquakes can make the fill fail; in lowlands the liquefaction tendency is very strong, especially on filled sea, lake or river beds.

Meiji-era lowland

-  Rice paddy 13%
-  River, pond or sea 1.2%

Memorials to natural disasters nearby



Numbered memorials; the black rectangle is the study area of this brief. Frame 16 km across.

Fewer than three memorials stand within 3 km of the study area, so the nearest ones within 8 km are listed.

	Memorial	Disaster	Erected	Distance
1	Memorial to the 1923 Great Kanto Earthquake 大震災記念碑	Great Kanto Earthquake (1 Sep 1923) · earthquake	1929	2.3 km
2	Monument on the site of the Imperial College of Engineering (Kobu Daigakko) 工部大学校址碑	Great Kanto Earthquake (1 Sep 1923) · earthquake	1939	4.4 km
3	Mizukake Jizo statues and memorial to the dead of the 1923 earthquake and fire 水掛け地蔵と大震災火災死亡群霊塔	Great Kanto Earthquake (1 Sep 1923) · earthquake	1924	4.4 km
4	Statue of Sho Kannon in memory of the 1923 Great Kanto Earthquake 震災記念聖観世音菩薩像	Great Kanto Earthquake (1 Sep 1923) · earthquake	1926	4.5 km
5	Monument where Emperor Showa stood to view the city's reconstruction in 1930 昭和天皇御野立所の碑	Great Kanto Earthquake (1 Sep 1923) · earthquake	unknown	5.2 km
6	Memorial for the tenth anniversary of the 1923 Great Kanto Earthquake 関東大震災十周年記念	Great Kanto Earthquake (1 Sep 1923) · earthquake	1933	5.7 km

What the memorials record

- 1. Memorial to the 1923 Great Kanto Earthquake.** In the Great Kanto Earthquake of 1 September 1923, the former Yotsuya Ward had 168 people killed or injured and 500 houses burned. Proposed by newspaper companies in the ward, the memorial was built with the support of 103 backers, including the ward assembly, neighborhood associations and trade associations. Its title was written by the then head priest of Zojoji.
- 2. Monument on the site of the Imperial College of Engineering (Kobu Daigakko).** The Great Kanto Earthquake of 1 September 1923, with more than 100,000 dead and more than 300,000 buildings destroyed or burned, was the largest natural disaster in Japan's history. The former Imperial College of Engineering building here collapsed; the Ministry of Education and the Board of Audit were built in its place. The monument is made from its bricks.
- 3. Mizukake Jizo statues and memorial to the dead of the 1923 earthquake and fire.** In the Great Kanto Earthquake of 1 September 1923 the former Ushigome Ward had 105 people killed or injured and 926 houses wholly or partly destroyed, but almost no fires, so it took in many evacuees. The memorial to the dead was erected the next year; the two standing Jizo statues came from the Gobyō Bridge on Mount Kōya.

4. Statue of Sho Kannon in memory of the 1923 Great Kanto Earthquake. Fires broke out in many places after the Great Kanto Earthquake of 1 September 1923, reducing the Shimbashi, Atago and Hamamatsucho areas to ashes. In Shiba Ward, now part of Minato Ward, nearly half of all households were burned out, and the dead were cremated here at Densoin temple.

5. Monument where Emperor Showa stood to view the city's reconstruction in 1930. The Great Kanto Earthquake of 1 September 1923 killed more than 100,000 people, and there were even rumours that the capital would be moved. In 1930, two days before the reconstruction celebrations, Emperor Showa stopped here first while inspecting the rebuilt downtown districts; Tokyo Bay could then be seen from this spot. The stone was rebuilt in 1989 after weathering.

6. Memorial for the tenth anniversary of the 1923 Great Kanto Earthquake. The Great Kanto Earthquake, at 11:58 am on 1 September 1923, left 99,331 dead and 43,476 missing, with 128,226 houses destroyed and 447,128 burned. The slogan carved on the monument, "For the sudden earthquake, constant readiness", urges people to remember the day and never let such a disaster happen again.

Source: GSI Natural Disaster Memorials (自然災害伝承碑). English names and notes are Japan Time Atlas translations and summaries of GSI's Japanese descriptions; the memorials' own inscriptions may say more. "Erected" is the year GSI records for the monument.

Sources

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9. 明治神宮の森：林学者や造園家によるナショナルプロジェクト [The forest of Meiji Shrine: a national project by foresters and landscape architects], nippon.com. <https://www.nippon.com/ja/japan-topics/g00866/>, checked 2026-09-28. Used for: The 1915 Construction Bureau, the forest's design by Honda Seiroku and colleagues, tree and volunteer numbers, and the outer garden's 1926 completion.
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Further reading

- 渋谷区史 (渋谷区編, 1952) — Shibuya City's own postwar history, covering the 1932 merger and the war years in more depth. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/3021838> (NDL individual digital transmission (registered users))

- *渋谷風土記 旧史編* (有田肇著, 1935) — A 1930s local history of the Shibuya area with detail on Onden and Harajuku's old villages. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/1233756> (NDL individual digital transmission (registered users))
- *千駄ヶ谷町誌* (中原慎太郎著, 1930) — A dedicated 1930 history of Sendagaya Town, published shortly before Meiji Shrine's outer garden was finished. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/1878561> (NDL individual digital transmission (registered users))
- *渋谷区史料集 第3 (諸家文書)* (渋谷区編, 1982) — Shibuya City's own published collection of family and estate documents relevant to the old Sendagaya and Onden landholders. <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/9642452> (NDL individual digital transmission (registered users))

Where a Deep Research request would go next

- **Washington Heights' daily life and its interaction with the surrounding neighborhood, 1946-1964** — US National Archives (NARA), Far East Command and Eighth Army records; GHQ/SCAP housing records. Search the NARA catalog for Washington Heights, Tokyo, and Eighth Army real-estate/housing files.
- **The 25 May 1945 Yamanote air raid's effect on Sendagaya specifically** — The Center of the Tokyo Raids and War Damage (東京大空襲・戦災資料センター) and Shibuya City's own archives. Consult their published raid-by-raid damage maps and any surviving ward-level accounts.
- **Household-level records for the merged Harajuku/Onden/Sendagaya villages before 1889** — Shibuya City Local History Museum (渋谷区郷土博物館・文学館) and the Tokyo Metropolitan Archives. Request the pre-merger village registers and cadastral maps held in their collections.
- **Meiji Shrine Construction Bureau's internal planning records and donor lists for the 1915-1920 forest project** — Meiji Shrine's own archives and the National Diet Library's Cabinet Library holdings. Apply to the shrine's history office and search the NDL Digital Collections for 明治神宮造営局 publications.

Caveats

- Yoyogi Park's own official page gives its opening date directly: 20 October 1967.
- The Onden/Shibuya River's exact culverting date is not given by any source read this session; it is described here only as having happened by the postwar decades, since only the river's present course and official path name could be verified.
- Village- and shrine-name etymologies (Harajuku, Onden, Sendagaya) are given as recorded in a 1917 town survey and an 1826-derived gazetteer compilation, which themselves note some traditions as oral or uncertain.
- Meiji Shrine's own founding traditions and the exact wartime casualty picture for Sendagaya's air raids were outside what this session could verify from primary sources; only the shrine's own building-history chronology is used for 1945 and 1958.

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